

Analytical Writing

Organize Your Thoughts

Here are some things to keep in mind when you write a formal literary analysis essay:

1. Stay in the present tense.
2. Only use the third person.
3. ~~Don't~~ Do not use contractions.
4. Use a sophisticated sentence structure and vocabulary.
5. Use quotes from the text. This is your evidence. Properly integrate those quotes. See the last page of this document.
6. Follow the MLA rules for formatting. When in doubt, [look it up](#).

***The first thing to do is understand and then think deeply about the literature. What is at the heart of the story? What is the deeper meaning? Only after you do this deep thinking can you write an engaging essay.*

The Intro:

<u>Hook</u> your reader's attention.	Engage your audience with: • A general insight directly related to your topic • A shocking statement or stat related to your topic • A quotation or rhetorical question that amplifies your main point	
<u>Intro</u> your topic with context.	Set the context by: • Introducing your topic • Gradually narrowing the focus of your topic • Include the author and title	
<u>Thesis</u> statement with your claim.	Write a thesis that is: • Addressing the prompt, topic, or question • Significant • Specific • Supportable • Sophisticated and grammatically correct	

Body Paragraphs (A fully developed essay has three body paragraphs):

<u>Topic</u> sentence introducing your topic.	
<u>Lead</u> into your quote by setting it up with some context (the work, passage, plot, culture, or history).	
<u>Evidence</u> Use a quote that supports your answer.	
<u>Analyze!</u> Explain WHY your quote is important and HOW your quote supports your answer.	
<u>Lead</u> into your quote by setting it up with some context (the work, passage, plot, culture, or history).	
<u>Evidence</u> Use a quote that supports your answer.	
<u>Analyze!</u> Explain WHY your quote is important and HOW your quote supports your answer.	
<u>Finish</u> with a concluding sentence. Use a definitive word.	Clearly, As you can see, Without a doubt, Surely, Truly, Therefore, Obviously, Thus, For these reasons,

Conclusion:

Refer to the <u>T</u>hesis.	Subtly refer to your main idea to reinforce your point. Do not belabor your point by overtly restating your thesis.	
<u>A</u>nswer So-what?	Provide a larger significance. Offer insight to extend the significance of the topic. Set discussion in larger context. Why does this matter?	
Echo The <u>H</u>ook.	Subtly echo your intro / Your lead. Link the intro and conclusion (reiterate a word or phrase)	

Integrating Quotes:

Once you've selected the passage you want to quote, work the material into your paper in as naturally as you can. You don't want to just drop quotes into the middle of your paper without any kind of "set up. "

Example:

Opinion: Paul's mother in "The Rocking Horse Winner" doesn't love her children.

Quote: "when her children were present, she always felt the centre of her heart go hard."

THE A-B-C's OF QUOTE INTEGRATION:

- A. Begin with explanation:** Even though Mrs. Wilmot appears to love her children to the rest of the world, "when her children were present, she always felt the center of her heart go hard" (120).
- B. Begin with quote:** "She always felt the center of her heart go hard" because Mrs. Wilmot doesn't love her children even though she appears to be a loving mother to the rest of the world (120).
- C. Quote is inserted in the middle:** Mrs. Wilmot "always felt the center of heart go hard" when her children were present, but to the rest of the world, she appears to be a loving mother (120).